FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The days are gone when cyber fraud was a cottage industry running out of nondescript towns in Jharkhand or Rajasthan. Those starred desi conmen, preying on digital novices with basic tools, and scooting with a lakh or two at most. Now, that species has fast-forwarded itself up the evolutionary ladder. India must beware of the New Big Con. This mutant, a transnational crime virus of sorts, uses sophisticated cyber tools and deals in multiples of millions. It's no longer just old housewives getting duped of their pension money. The web of illusion is so hyperreal that it has befooled the likes of S.P. Oswal, chairman of the Vardhman Group, India's largest textile conglomerate. Our sample list of victims also features an ex-IGP persuaded to part with Rs 2.14 crore, a retired major general who lost Rs 82.27 lakh, even a lawyer teased out of Rs 24 lakh. In the first four months of this year, gullible Indians had lost Rs 120 crore to the New Con. Very likely, that's only the reported tip of the iceberg.

What's the genesis of this new phenomenon? A whole 21st-century supermarket of deception. We have entire cartels of 'fraudsters sans frontiers' out there. Dealing in everything from sextortion to stock market sleights of hand, they exacted a staggering financial toll of Rs 1,776 crore on India in just January-May 2024. These swindles are staged out of highly mobile bases all over Southeast Asian nations like Cambodia, Laos and Myanmar. Downstream is a scattered network of lowly Indian foot soldiers deployed at the last mile—themselves often 'cyber slaves' coerced into the trade. Lurking behind are kingpins whose shadowy slipstreams frequently lead to China. After a heist, the con artists stage a perfect digital getaway via a labyrinth of newfangled financial highways, their footprints vanishing into the internet's cracks. At one end of this heist are corrupt bank officials and humble 'mule accounts'. On the other is a hall of mirrors with untraceable offshore accounts and cryptocurrency. The menace is so rampant that Prime Minister Narendra Modi was driven to issue a warning about it in his *Mann ki Baat* radio broadcast on October 27.



October 30, 2023

The master key of the New Con is fear. It preys on people's instinctual paranoia at the thought of being picked on by the law, a zone where the process becomes the punishment. The sting begins with an officious voice on the phone, informing a target that their name, Aadhaar or PAN info has cropped up in a crime investigation. Jaipur bank manager Tanvi Jain was told her SIM card had been linked to a money-laundering scam. Young Bengaluru techie Rabia Thakur panicked when notified of a suspicious FedEx package containing drugs in her name. In short, mention a crime severe enough to impart a jolt of terror, and most crumble. To escape immediate prison or an unending legal miasma, victims are told they must cooperate. Stricken by the fear of infamy, they obey the next commandment: do not tell anyone as it could lead to severe repercussions.

Then begins a strange drama called the 'digital arrest', whose arena and stage props are half-technological, half-psychological. A Bhopal doctor, shaken up by a contraband charge, was told to download Skype for a video 'interrogation'. Victims are led to believe they are in virtual detention. A floating posse of imposters put up a bravura live performance, impersonating cops or officials from the CBI, Enforcement Directorate or the Narcotics Control Bureau. Victims see what appears to be an actual police station, staged down to the last detail. Walkie-talkies buzz intermittently, and mundane clerical activity and legit-looking paraphernalia fill the background. Along with stern voices of authority, the visual and auditory cues inveigle them into a nightmare that seems real. Oswal, incredibly, was subjected to an entire 'Supreme Court session' over Skype, with an actor impersonating former Chief Justice of India D.Y. Chandrachud. Scammers create these phantom doubles using deepfake technology, with voice, speech patterns and facial simulations indistinguishable from the original! The ordeal could last days and end only after they comply with the demand for a 'security deposit' that can quickly go into crores.

How come even ex-cops and lawyers fall for the ruse? Perhaps just an innate distrust of the system, maybe a sense of alarm that the law indeed has something on them: targets are zeroed in on through precise digital profiling, using purloined Aadhaar details, recent foreign travels, online activity and suchlike. Everyone may have some inconvenient fact or two tucked away. Psychologists say it's a paralysis of fear. A sudden plunge into precarity induces a 'fight, flight or freeze' response—mostly the last. Pure terror abolishes rational thought. An Agra schoolteacher, when told her daughter had been caught in a sex racket, succumbed to a cardiac arrest. The Bengaluru lawyer was psyched into submitting to an online 'strip search'. The INDIA TODAY bureau brings together such stories from across the country to paint this post-modern canvas of crime. Given its international scope, both the real culprits and the stolen money are often beyond reach. So, creating awareness is the best cure. As an ex-finance official put it, "This scam will not happen if you just hang up the phone." There is an old legal maxim in Latin, *caveat emptor,* or buyer beware. So, dear reader, be careful when you part with your money.

(Aroon Purie)